Section 3: UX Failure Analysis

Overview

The reason Kavindu Silva fails repeatedly when trying to maintain any financial tracking system does not stem from a lack of understanding and knowledge or even intention, but from being bombarded with incompatible software. Throughout the year, he tried out four different solutions, namely a Google Sheet spreadsheet, an application for budgeting purposes, an application for taking notes, and even the system used by his bank.

While these systems may be very different from each other, they have the same problems with regards to usability. It is important to note that the failures are not because of missing functionality, but lack of compatibility between the system and actual behavior. Hence, it is imperative that FinPilot be designed not only for functionality, but also for compatibility with behaviors.

Failure Breakdown of Existing Tools

Tool	Core Issue	UX Failure	Outcome
Google Sheets	Manual tracking	High effort, fragile formulas	Abandoned due to maintenance burden
Budgeting App	Rigid structure	Assumes fixed income, single currency	Inaccurate and irrelevant
Notes App	No structure	Unorganized data, no categorization	Becomes unreadable
Bank App	Partial visibility	Missing cash + misclassification	Loss of trust

Why These Systems Failed

3.1 High Friction in Data Entry

All tools required consistent manual input. Kavindu initially engages with systems but abandons them when effort outweighs perceived benefit. The requirement to repeatedly input transactions, maintain structure, or correct errors introduces friction that interrupts daily usage.

This indicates that long-term adherence is directly dependent on minimizing the effort required per interaction.

3.2 Rigid Financial Models

Most tools assume:

- A fixed monthly salary
- A single income source
- A single currency

Kavindu's income structure directly contradicts these assumptions. Systems that cannot adapt to irregular, multi-source income produce inaccurate insights, making them functionally useless.

3.3 Lack of Meaningful Feedback

None of the tools provided immediate, clear insights into:

- Where money is going
- How income is distributed
- Whether progress toward goals is being made

Without visible outcomes, the act of tracking feels pointless. Kavindu does not receive any psychological reward for maintaining the system, leading to rapid disengagement.

3.4 Poor Information Architecture

In some tools (e.g. notes), flexibility came at the cost of structure. In others (e.g. bank apps), categorization was incorrect or incomplete.

This resulted in:

- Data that cannot be interpreted
- Misleading summaries
- Loss of confidence in the system

A system that cannot present information clearly is equivalent to having no system at all.

3.5 Incomplete Financial Visibility

Existing solutions fail to capture all financial activity in one place. Cash expenses, secondary accounts, and subscriptions remain untracked or fragmented across platforms.

This fragmentation prevents Kavindu from forming a complete mental model of his finances, reinforcing his core frustration: *not knowing where his money goes*.

Behavioral Insights

Kavindu's behavior reveals several critical patterns:

- He is willing to start tracking but unwilling to sustain high-effort systems
- He avoids tools that feel complex, rigid, or time-consuming
- He requires quick interactions that fit into daily life

- He does not naturally think in structured financial categories
- He is motivated by clarity, not raw data

These patterns suggest that system success depends more on usability and feedback than on feature depth.

Key Insight

All previous tools failed because they required high effort, enforced rigid assumptions, and failed to provide meaningful, immediate insights. The core issue is not the absence of functionality, but the absence of alignment between system design and user behavior.

A successful system must reduce effort, adapt to financial complexity, and continuously reinforce value through clear and immediate feedback.

Design Implications for FinPilot

- **Low-friction data entry:** Minimal steps required to record income and expenses
- **Flexible financial modeling:** Support for irregular, multi-source, multi-currency income
- **Unified financial view:** All income and expenses visible in one system
- **Clear visual feedback:** Dashboards and charts that immediately show insights
- **Assisted categorization:** Reduce user effort in organizing financial data
- **Accurate and complete tracking:** Include cash, subscriptions, and secondary accounts
- **Daily usability:** Interactions must be fast, simple, and repeatable without effort